

Maurice Halbwachs – Collectives Memory and Forgetting¹

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Introduction

The French sociologist Maurice Halbwachs (1877-1945) is generally considered to be *the* classic reference of the sociology of memory.² The central object of inquiry in his studies on memory is collective memory.³ Various reproaches have been directed at both Halbwachs and the Durkheim school as a whole for having underestimated the significance of forgetting in the reconstruction of the process of memory, as well as at Halbwachs in particular for not having taken into account what psychoanalysis had to say about forgetting (Brian 2008). Halbwachs, however, by no means ignored Freud; instead he explicitly provided a critical discussion of him in one of his three main works on the theory of memory, i.e. in *Cadres Sociaux de la mémoire (The Social Frameworks of Memory)* ([1925] 1992).⁴ According to Jan Assmann, the elaborate indications provided in this work on the significance of frameworks can explain not only memory but also *forgetting* (Assmann 2007: 36). How is this possible? In his work, Halbwachs repeatedly discussed the value of various social frames of reference

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² On this point, see also Wetzel (2009a and 2009b), Coser (1992a and 1992b) and the volume edited by Stephan Egger with elaborations and a critique of Halbwachs (Egger 2003). Interestingly, the English experimental psychologist F. C. Bartlett (1923) arrived at a similar approach to Halbwachs' around the same time, and his work was later developed by authors such as Middleton and Edwards (1990) into a 'social-constructivist theory of memory'.

³ Halbwachs' status as a classic of the sociology of memory stems essentially from three works: *Les Cadres Sociaux de la mémoire* (1925, Eng. 199), *La mémoire collective* (1950, Eng. 1980), and *La topographie légendaire des évangiles en Terre sainte* (1941, Eng. 1992).

⁴ Halbwachs' discussion of Freud is concentrated in the chapter on 'Dreams and Memory Images' (pp. 41-42) and 'Language and Memory' (pp. 43-45). Halbwachs shared with Freud the insight according to which memory is based on the interplay between repetition and rediscovery, whereby, however, memory obeys a social dynamic and not the psychological one assumed by Freud (see, Hutton 1994: 149). Hutton points out three more crucial points in relation to Halbwachs: 'First, he contended that in repetition memories are not transmitted intact. Rather they are conflated as they are being continuously revised. In each repetition of an experience, particular idiosyncrasies are worn away. That which is remembered of often repeated experience is a reduction of particular memories into an idealized image, or imago. Second, he proposed that in recollection memories are reconstructed within social contexts' (ibid, 149). Finally, Halbwachs did not hold dreams, designated by Freud as the 'royal way to the unconscious', to be suitable for understanding the processes of memory, because dreams are detached from social contexts: 'We cannot remember while we are dreaming because our social contexts have been removed' (ibid. 150).

(*cadres sociaux*). Above all, these comprise the family, religion, social classes, etc. Individuals initially develop their social identities through their belonging to such frameworks. In addition, Halbwachs' research yielded one of the key contemporary insights according to which memory does not simply conserve the past, but incessantly reconstructs it from past occurrences in the light of the present (Montigny 2005, Gierl 2005). This raises the general question as to which role forgetting plays in the process of memory. Ostensibly, this question arises after the transformation of what has been, and indeed both from the angle of what *has been transformed* (what has been forgotten?) and from that of the *receiving individual* (who has forgotten what?).⁵ Halbwachs, according to the argument I am putting forward here, provided a thoroughly plausible explanation of forgetting in the framework of his theory of memory. Nonetheless, his theory is in need of critical elaborations if his insights are to be inserted into recent research on the processes of memory and forgetting.

In the first place, this article thematizes the basic features of Halbwachs' theory of memory. Its central explanatory aspects will be explained as will the important distinction, crucial for Halbwachs among others, between collective and individual memory. For, without understanding how memory functions, it is impossible to comprehend forgetting (Section 1). Subsequent to this, the following section sketches the contours of Halbwachs' theory of memory and forgetting. In particular, light is shed on the role of social frames (*cadres sociaux*) as well as on the distinction between individual and collective forgetting (Section 2). Focusing on the dimension of forgetting, the next part undertakes a more extensive and critical look at Halbwachs by presenting the approaches of Paul Ricœur as well as Aleida and Jan Assmann. This yields critical refinements and developments that address, for example, the interlacing of memory and forgetting as consolidated by research in the philosophy of language (Ricœur), or the blending of the dimensions of alterity and conflict (Aleida and Jan Assmann). Such an approach provides interesting refinements for research on memory (Section 3). In a concluding chapter, I sum up the most important points and attempt to establish a connection to current topics of research (Section 4).

1. Basic features of Halbwachs' theory of memory

⁵ With Elena Esposito, it could even be argued that 'memory is responsible for the loss of contents rather than for their retention', 'for forgetting rather than for recollection. The form of memory does not consist in the identity of the memory, but in the difference *memory/forgetting*' (2002: 27).

1.1 Conceiving memory sociologically

A sociologist who proceeded both theoretical and empirically, Halbwachs – whose concept of collective memory was left incomplete due to his violent death in the year of 1945 – used the term *mémoire collective* to define a fundamental aspect of social life. Halbwachs set out to grasp the mental interplay of specific individuals with the persistence of particular socialities, and moreover in all the positive as well as negative manifestations. As an ambitious sociologist, he wanted to open up a domain that not only recurred on every level of sociology, but – and here we see his ambitiousness – that defined its complete point of view. Memory, for Halbwachs, was to be understood as a *reconstruction of the past*, one that, more precisely, finds assistance in present occurrences. These latter are *cadres* or frameworks situated in the present which enable each particular group to recollect. Actual memories are prepared by means of other, already earlier undertaken reconstructions, from which a past image always emerges – more or less strongly – altered (Halbwachs 1967: 55f.). Jan Assmann qualifies this theory of memory as a productive conjunction between a theory of collective consciousness adopted from Durkheim, and a *presentistic and reconstructive theory of memory* that allegedly borrows from Bergson as well as the (largely silent) Nietzsche (2005).

Along what lines can Halbwachs' concept of memory be summarized? In his article, as meticulous as it is insightful, Walter Gierl (2005: 165) describes the notable achievements of the French sociologist's theory of memory in three points. In accordance with Halbwachs, then, a memory – and this is the first point – can never be exactly the same, 'since the reconstructed present is by definition always another' (ibid.). 'Moreover, the particular collectivity is a reservoir of incessantly changing perspectives and the concerned individuals and collectivities change and intersect with one another always afresh'. And lastly: 'Because memory thus loses every lasting substance, external conditions become very important and the successful delimitations form governors of the identical' (ibid.). Added to this, as Jan Assmann notes, is the fact that the collective memory operates not only in one but in both directions: 'backwards and forwards. Not only does memory reconstruct the past, it also organizes the experience of the present and the future' (Assmann 2007: 42). This is precisely the past that Halbwachs' theory of memory renders graspable as a *social construction*. The past is a social construction that explicitly 'appears out of the needs of meaning and frames of reference of the particular present' (Halbwachs 1985: 48).

The *process of memory*, then, can be understood as follows: each individual has *his* own memories and has the potential of *his* memory at his disposal. This does not mean, however, ‘that what the individual remembers is invented. Memory is to a large extent exempt from command; often even in one’s inner self the past is inescapable. It simply *happens* that what has past asserts its present to the point of being plaguing, and even traumatically overwhelming’ (Schenk 2008: 24).⁶ To understand this better, a distinction is required that Halbwachs often discussed in this work, namely that between collective and individual memory.

1.2 *Collective and individual memory*

For the sociological examination of forgetting, the comparison between collective and individual memory constitutes an important prerequisite. Halbwachs viewed the processes of memory and forgetting as ‘genuine social practices’, whereby he ‘argued against all psychological or psychoanalytic assumptions as to the autonomy of individual memory’ (Butzer/Günter 2004: 9). On this view, individual and collective memories mutually penetrate one another (on this point, compare Section 3.1). Memory is individual insofar as it functions in the sense of an always unique connection of collective memories, that is, as the place of various group-related memories and their always specific connection (Assmann 2007: 37). While various collective memories are inevitably ‘superimposed’ within the individual memory, due to the various group-belonging of individuals, the collective memory is also appropriated by these individuals in accordance with their milieu and the relationships obtaining within them. That is why collective memory is also unable to determine wholly the process of reconstruction concerning the past of a specific individual. But at the same time, wrote Halbwachs, the procedure of individual memory ‘is impossible without those instruments, which are formed through words and representations, and which the individual did not invent but borrowed from his milieu’ (Halbwachs 1967: 35).

By considering an individual’s moment of expression, Halbwachs’ was responding to the critique of his Strassburgian colleague and psychologist Charles Blondel, who, as a social psychologist, emphasized the persistence of sensory impressions in the individual (Blondel 1926, 1948), impressions presented as in themselves enabling of

⁶ Halbwachs does not give any systematic examination of the above-mentioned figure of traumatic memory, that is, of not-being-able-to-forget.

memory. At the same time, Halbwachs' work manages to mitigate Durkheim's well-known sociological determinism (Montigny 2005: 44). Fractures seem to emerge again and again between individual appropriation and collective memory. Each sequence of memories is accompanied by fractures, displacements and transformations, which is tantamount to saying that the experienced life history of the individual is interwoven with history in general. This simultaneously means, however, that individual memory precisely does not coincide with the collective memory, for the latter is much more comprehensive (Krämer 2000: 194).

How did Halbwachs present, in concrete terms, the interplay between both these components of memory? This he described in a long passage:

If, in addition, the collective memory derives its force and constancy from its resting on a collectivity of people, nonetheless it is the individuals who, as members of groups, do the recollecting. In this mass of common and mutually enabling memories it is not the same ones which appear the most clearly to each singular individual. It could be said that each individual memory is a 'point of view' of the collective memory; this point of view changes according to the place that I occupy and this place itself changes according to the relationships that I maintain with another's milieu' (Halbwachs 1967: 31).

Here we see a clear shift from Halbwachs' already published work of 1925 *Memory and its Social Conditions*, and it resides in the fact that it is first the individual that recollects and precisely not (only) the group as abstract unity. Second, the collective memory serves these groups as a sort of common reservoir, on which the individual gazes according to a *point of view*. The immediate givens of consciousness therefore comprise neither pure individual memory (Bergson 1991) nor a collective memory that is effectively placed on the individual from the outside. It is much more a matter of an interaction between the two. In other words: even the most personal memories can always be explained by the shifts arising from our relationship to our various milieus, that is, ultimately from the changes in each one of these milieus and in their totality. In his work prior to the publication of *The Collective Memory* (1950, Eng. 1980), collective memory as such seemed quasi-fixed and the individual explainable only through the social; here, however, the concept appears to have been submitted to differentiation and – with regard to the individual memory – a *relational interpretation*. How, then, are we to understand the interrelation presented in this theory, which can be qualified as *social* and *constructivist*, between memory, remembering, and forgetting?

2. Halbwachs' Theory of forgetting (and of remembering)

2.1 *The role of ‘cadres’ (frameworks) in the process of remembering and forgetting*

In the following passage, Halbwachs provides his understanding of frames of references. He starts from the premise,

that the collective frames of reference of memories are not formed afterwards through the combination of individual memory contents, and that nor are they simply empty form in which memories settle after coming from elsewhere, but that, by contrast, they are instruments which the collective memory uses in order to reconstruct an image of the past in harmony with the ruling notions of the society of a particular era (Halbwachs 1985: 22/23).

The first, most important collective frames of references or social frameworks (*cadres sociaux*) are language, time, space and experience.⁷ Of all the frameworks, language is the most elementary and simultaneously the most stable in relation with group memory. The frames of time and space cater for the fixing of events (dating) and historical situating of memories (archiving). Further forms and categories derive from the frames of experience(s), which encompass historical, geographical and politically relevant terms as well as everyday events and historical occurrences. Halbwachs’ general *relational representation* regarding the changeability of frameworks in the context of social structures can be considered remarkable for his time: ‘Each time that we integrate our impressions into the frameworks of our current representations, the framework changes the impression, but in its turn the impression also modifies the framework’ (1985: 189). It is this mutual formability of the thereby connected structures that reveals Halbwachs as a contemporary theoretician: ‘By considering already the discontinuous alteration and internal processuality of such structures, Halbwachs anticipated a central point of critique which post-structuralism was in turn to advance against structuralism’ (Quadflieg 2007: 409). Halbwachs was convinced that memory can only succeed with the help of ‘social frames’. The advantage of such a perspective resides in the fact that it can explain both recollection *and* forgetting. Jan Assmann emphasizes this achievement of Halbwachs’ theory of memory: ‘If an individual – and a society – is only capable of recollecting that which is re-constructible within the frames of reference of a particular present, then what is forgotten is precisely that which has no longer any frames of reference in such a present’ (Assmann 2007: 36).⁸ In other words: forgetting is also tied in with such social frameworks, or is conditioned by changes of

⁷ This concept of social frameworks is reminiscent of the theory of frame analysis developed by Erving Goffman in the 1970s. The frame organizing everyday experience in Goffman corresponds to the ‘frames’ in Halbwachs, which memories constitute as much as stabilize (Goffman 1977).

⁸ For this, Jan Assmann coined the term of ‘parallelism of framing conditions’ for memory and forgetting (1991: 346).

frameworks, which for their part come about through ‘the complete change of conditions of life and social relations’ (Assmann 1991: 345).

Forgetting is explained by the disappearing of this framework or a part thereof, either because our attention was not up to the task of fixing itself on them, or because it was directed elsewhere [...]. The forgetting or distortion of specific memories, however, can be explained by the fact that these frameworks change from one period of time to another’ (Halbwachs 1985: 368).

Decisive here for Halbwachs is the fact that each group belonging is bestowed with an index of time. In the framework of his *Theory of Social Time* (Halbwachs 1967: 78f.), memory presupposes a periodization or social construction of time. Only with the help of social frames of memory can the changes of temporal structures of a society be recognized. A change of frames thus always simultaneously means a change of time and therewith is tied to a forgetting. ‘As Gérard Namer says in summing up this passage of Halbwachs’ towards a theory of collective forgetting, “forgetting means to create another memory, by developing a new collective memory”’ (Cited in Krämer 1999: 270/271).

A second, albeit rather implicit, dimension of forgetting results from the selectivity of the framework itself. Whatever is unable to fit into the frameworks that a society tolerates is eliminated. Halbwachs once again:

That is why a society tends to exclude from its memory that which separates individuals from one another, and which could distance groups from one another, and for this reason in each epoch it manipulates its memories in order to bring about concordance with its changeable conditions of equilibrium (Halbwachs 1985: 382).

Memories are thus not simply reconstructed, but instead ‘distorted, because there is a desire to introduce more coherence into them’ (ibid.). Concerning the processes of selection, reconstruction and distortion of memory, Halbwachs always referred to groups that were decisive for what came to be remembered and what, accordingly, forgotten. This can be clearly seen in a passage from *The Legendary Topography of the Gospels in the Holy Land*, in which Halbwachs showed the extent to which the life of Jesus Christ was only selectively retained in the memory of the (early) Christians, which he put down to the fact that wholly specific groups were able to ‘enforce’ themselves during the religious forming of Christianity (Halbwachs 1992b). Here we also see that Halbwachs’ theory of forgetting clearly takes aspects of conflicts and struggles for power into consideration. Yet, such aspects and struggles remained implicit and were never systematically taken into account. Nonetheless, these issues

seem rather crucial with regard to the question of individual and collective forgetting, and so it is to these that the focus now turns.

2.2 Individual and collective forgetting

For Halbwachs, the social frames of memories always contain the recollection of others. The individual requires these recollections of others in order to be able to recollect at all. Here the individual memory serves ‘as a recording device, that is, it registers the most diverse influences, and thereby is actually another way of looking at collective memory. Individual and collective memories interact with one another’ (Krämer 1999: 270). Which tasks does individual forgetting fulfill? To start with, individual forgetting protects us through a *structural amnesia* against the threat of a profusion of information.⁹ Winkler suggests that this selection process proceeds without conscious control and that even contents believed-to-be totally forgotten ‘can emerge again, causing surprise (and trauma)’, which, in turn, comprises ‘the daemonic character of this faculty’ (Winkler 2001: 629). To this extent, forgetting is not tantamount to an act of complete deletion. And neither can memory obtain in the absence of forgetting. The forgotten as area of the possible always exhibits a larger extension than the presently real, and consequently than the remembered (Butzer/Günter 2004: 13).¹⁰

At the beginning of his third major work, *Collective Memory* (1980), Halbwachs outlines the process of ‘forgetting through separation from a group’:

To forget a section of one’s life means: to lose the connection to those people who surrounded us at the time. To forget a foreign language means: to be capable no longer of understanding the people who addressed us in that language – whether they are alive and present or authors whose work we once read. [...] In the case that there are no existing pathological disturbances, if we remove and isolate ourselves gradually in a perhaps less abrupt and brutal way from some milieu, these latter do not forget us, but we nonetheless keep them only vaguely in memory. We can still describe the groups to which we belonged in general terms. But they no longer interest us, because everything in the present separates them from us (Halbwachs 1967: 10/11).

Upon separation from group relationships even forgotten perceptions leave traces behind, a fact vividly described by the founding father of psychoanalysis, Sigmund

⁹ By structural amnesia or ‘homeostasis’ is to be understood a continuous process of adapting the collective memory to the immediate constraints of the present. Whatever is no longer of significance is eliminated through forgetting.

¹⁰ Currently a debate is taking place over so-called willed and unwilled forgetting. A particular form of this willed forgetting is symbolized by the ‘pill of forgetting’ in the film *The Matrix*. That this is more than mere science fiction is shown with a consideration of trauma. With traumatic events those concerned want actively to forget, or suppress.

Freud (1975 [1925]), with the memory metaphor of the *Wunderblock*, or mystic writing pad. In addition, this changes ‘the structure of expectation, with whose help we orient ourselves in the world, the structure of our subjectivity and our implicit font of knowledge’ (Winkler 2001: 629/630). Here a clear difference is revealed between Halbwachs and Freud, for the former notably took into consideration the possibility that after a separation from a group no ‘trace’ any longer remains. Halbwachs claimed that something like a ‘seed of memory’ (Halbwachs 1967: 5) is required if memory is not to disappear altogether:

If, however, this event of (remembering) seems to have left no trace behind in our memory, i.e., if we feel incapable of reconstructing it even partially because of a lack of witnesses, one can give us a vivid description of it – it will nevertheless not be a memory (ibid.: 5).

In psychoanalysis itself, Theodor Reik, in his ‘On Collective Forgetting’ (1920), made the most distinctive contribution to furthering Freud’s idea. According to his main premise ‘in the majority of cases of collective forgetting, specific unconscious motives have caused a disturbance of reproduction’ (1920: 213). While psychoanalysis relativizes the concept of forgetting through the mechanism of repression – Reik spoke of the ‘forces of repression’ (ibid. 214) – and displacement,¹¹ Halbwachs saw social frameworks and the thereby imparted memories of others as essential for the dialectic between memory and forgetting. Even the seemingly most personal memory, which we can attest to as an individual; even unspoken thoughts and feelings, stand in relation to concepts and semantic fields, which many others have at their disposal apart from oneself. Otherwise put: in remembering we draw from a reservoir constituted through others as well as in connection with social frameworks (family, religious groups, virtual communities, etc.). According to Halbwachs, we are always involved in a permanent and necessary exchange with the material and mental life of groups to which we belonged or which we continue to belong (Halbwachs 1985: 71). Here again, Halbwachs, *pace* Bergson amongst others, clearly understands memory as a *relational form of organization*.¹²

3. Developments and critiques of Halbwachs

3.1. Ricœur’s critical reception of Halbwachs’ works on forgetting

¹¹ Insofar as Freud assumed that the unconscious never really forgets, he said: ‘It is indeed an outstanding peculiarity of the unconscious processes that they are indestructible. Nothing can be brought to an end in the unconscious, nothing is past or forgotten’ (Freud 1989 [1900]: 355-6).

¹² To this extent here we can observe the absolute beginnings of the type of relational sociology that came to be elaborated by Pierre Bourdieu and Loïc Wacquant (Bourdieu & Wacquant 1996).

Many works in French social philosophy by Paul Ricoeur (1913–2005) endeavour precisely to examine the studies on memory undertaken by Halbwachs (Ricoeur 1998, 2003, 2004). Halbwachs became important for Ricoeur, precisely because, as he admitted, his own early work underestimated the significance of (collective) memories (Ricoeur 2004: 187). Nevertheless, Ricoeur expressed concern with respect to the conception of a collective memory as a subject of memory encountered in Halbwachs:

»But [...] to assume a collective subject of memory is a step that is more difficult to accomplish. [...] It would imply that the collective memory of a group fulfills the same functions of retention, organization and of calling-to-memory or bringing-to-mind that is attributed to the individual memory. Halbwachs seems to take this step without really examining its assumptions (Ricoeur 1998: 79).

By means of his phenomenological-aporetic approach – and in contrast with Halbwachs distinctly non-constructivist one – Ricoeur, it seems, was able to avoid this difficulty (1998: 72f.). Halbwachs' familiarity with statistical demographical methods conceivably led him to overvalue this instrument as regards the measurability of collective memories. Moreover, Ricoeur sees a further difficulty in Halbwachs', 'as it were, Leibnizian use of the idea of point of view, of perspective' (Ricoeur 2004: 192), so central for the mediation of individual and collective memory. As Ricoeur put it:

»What ultimately weakens Maurice Halbwachs's position is his recourse to a sense data based theory of sensible intuition. This recourse will become more difficult after the linguistic turn and, even more so, after the pragmatic turn taken by the epistemology of history« (2006: 523, FN 33).

Radicalizing Halbwachs, Ricoeur grasped memory as necessarily linked to a *narrative structure*, i.e. as narratively structured.¹³ Memories only become socially living if they are recounted and exchanged. This means that memory is constructive and thus always also selective, since it requires a governing narrative logic and the concomitant obligation to establish tension and ensure a structure of meaning. Paradoxically formulated: selective memory is also always selective forgetting (Ricoeur 2003: 43).

The process of mediation between various language games is social and public in nature. Thus, because memories are exchanged through (social) language, they themselves cannot be primarily private in nature. With reference to Halbwachs,

¹³ This, on the other hand, seems to be one-sided insofar as we know from traumatized people that their memories haunt them in the form of images.

Ricœur managed to provide a tenable phenomenology of the simultaneous, mutual and intersecting constitution of individual and collective memory' (Ricœur 1998: 84). This he based on the concept of *historical consciousness*, as conceived by Reinhart Koselleck in his work *Futures Past* (2004 [1979]). According to this concept, basic polarities arise between the space of experience and the horizon of expectation, in which our space of experience comprises the past events which constitute the basis for the directionality of the future. According to Ricœur, an exchange is formed between the space of experience and the horizon of expectation, conditioned by the living present of a culture and, precisely, not only by reduction to a single moment. Finally, moreover, a growing dynamic of historical consciousness emerges from the feeling of orientation within the flow of time. In this context, the horizon of expectation works to lend meaning, or precisely meaninglessness, to our present.

Furthermore, Ricœur came to attribute *forgetting* a key position. Somewhat paradoxically, he construed it as enabling of memory in general. To this end, he quoted Heidegger approvingly: 'just as expecting is only possible on the basis of awaiting, *remembering* is possible only on that of forgetting, *and not vice versa*; for in the mode of having-forgotten, one's having-been 'discloses' primarily the horizon into which a Dasein lost in the 'superficiality' of its object of concern, can bring itself by remembering (2003: 43). This thesis – already thematized by Halbwachs – concerning the entwining of memory and forgetting is more fully explained by Ricœur in his short text on 'Remembering and Forgetting: the willful persistence of images' (2003). In it, Ricœur argued that there exist two aspects of memory, which not only interpenetrate one another, but also function enigmatically. First, there is *the cognitive side of memory*, in which we encounter an interplay between absence and presence. In this way, striking events take place which leave behind traces (neuronal, archival, and affective). Any such trace is the effect of a cause (present) and the sign of a cause which it does not exhibit (absent).¹⁴ At this point, moreover, a crucial distinction arises between imagination and memory. The key dimension that distinguishes memory from imagination is that of time. While both point to absences, only memory refers to the past and thereby presupposes a forgetting. Second, there is *the pragmatic side of memory*. Here, it is possible, in turn, to distinguish two

¹⁴ If we are reminded of the other, bring him to mind, then at the outside we register his traces. From history we have learnt that there is a duty to remember if a guilt obligates us to do so. Ricœur once again: "If there exists a duty to remember, then it is for the sake of the guilt, which memory, by turning it toward the future, places in the future in the truest sense of the word, in the future tense: You shall remember! You shall not forget! In this respect guilt is scarcely a correlate and even less a synonym of the trace. The trace demands to be pursued; it is a pure reference to the past; it does not obligate, it signifies" (1998: 56).

aspects: on the one hand, the passive persistence of memory; and on the other, and its active repetition, which is tied to particular efforts, due to the fact that (selective) contexts have to be sought that obey narrative logic. Ricoeur identified three types of unconscious/forgotten continuation: (1) grammar (procedural); (2) transcendental; and (3) immemorial (mythical). Through these differentiations, or rather his phenomenological method, Ricoeur succeeded in advancing our understanding of the process of forgetting.¹⁵

3.2 Jan and Aleida Assmann: alterity, conflict and the transformation of memory frames

In the multiple works that they have published since the 1980s, Aleida and Jan Assmann have endeavoured to develop a *Theory of Cultural Memory* (J. Assmann 1988, 2007, A. Assmann 2001, 2006). Their relation to Halbwachs is at once both sympathetic as well as critical. Aleida Assmann, in particular, aims to distinguish herself clearly from Halbwachs, in suggesting that Halbwachs' conception of collective memory is type a 'memory of will', and essentially represents a sort of 'polemical counter construction to other existing kinds of collective memory' (A. Assmann 2002: 186). Interestingly, for Aleida Assmann 'collective memory' so conceived represents a 'radical constriction' as far as the process and task of passing knowledge on from generation to generation is concerned. On this basis, then, she is able to substitute a seemingly narrow type of collective memory with a more encompassing cultural memory. What exactly do Aleida and Jan Assmann understand by cultural memory? 'Under the term of cultural memory', they write, 'we understand the stock, specific to every society and every era, of reusable texts, images and rites, in the 'care', or use, of which a society or era stabilizes and conveys its self-image; it is a collectively shared knowledge, which is primarily, but not exclusively, about the past, and on which a group founds its consciousness of unity and uniqueness' (Assmann 1988: 15). In contrast with cultural memory, which is essentially defined through its distance from the everyday, communicative memory is characterized by its proximity to the everyday; it is manifest as a short-term memory linked to people and spread through communication, and spans approximately 80 years, thus three to four generations. On the other hand, for Aleida and Jan Assmann, forgetting is

¹⁵ Interestingly, in his works on forgetting Ricoeur referred particularly often Halbwachs' teacher Henri Bergson (2004: 652f.). This trio of authors Bergson/Halbwachs/Ricoeur offer material for an independent examination.

an integral part of remembering; we can only remember because we can also forget and do so antecedently and unintentionally. This fading and losing of experiences and memories is a part of everyday normality. Memory is indeed no exact storehouse, but instead a dynamic organ of adapting to a changing present and therefore can always adjust to new things (A. Assmann 2006: 104).

Jan Assmann claims that this dynamics of memory – which Halbwachs himself discusses – is complemented by the process of *transformation of frameworks of memory*. For Assmann, remembering entails the constituting of meaning for experiences within a framework; forgetting, by contrast, stands for a ‘change of the framework, whereby determinate memories become meaningless and are therefore forgotten, while others settle into new patterns of relationship and are therefore remembered’ (1991: 347). Neither memory nor forgetting, however, inevitably have to take place in a harmonious, consensus-oriented framework. This fact is what Aleida and Jan Assmann find lacking in the works of Halbwachs; in particular, they criticize the lack of any *conception of conflict* in his sociology of memory (on this point, see Quindeau 2004: 104). In principle, collective memory works to foster the cohesion and agreement of a group. This cohesive function, however, is necessarily accompanied by processes of exclusion against, and differentiation from, other groups. Every constitution of identity simultaneously implies the production of alterity (Assmann & Assmann 1990: 27).¹⁶ Halbwachs himself at best arrived at an implicit thematization – for example, with his question into the process of remembering – of this reserve side of cohesion, which only distinctly manifests itself through the inclusion of alterity and conflict. In this way, however, neither conflicting memories within or between groups, nor conflicts that result from different memories, can be understood.¹⁷ And that there are diverse, and also absolutely disputed, collective memories is discernible not only in ethnic and religious groups, but also within families. Moreover, the productive dimension of conflicts (Simmel 1908: 349f.) is not given any detailed consideration in Halbwachs, which is all the more problematic seeing as groups are constituted through struggle as well as through consensus, that is, through the interaction of both forces together. This applies in turn for both processes: that of remembering and that of forgetting.¹⁸

¹⁶ That all formation of identity is necessarily based on alterity I show in Wetzel (2004b).

¹⁷ That with various forms of memory also involve ‘instruments of domination’, that ‘serve the staging and therewith the legitimization of the exercise of, and claims to, power’ is underlined by Christian Giordano (2002: 206).

¹⁸ Precisely this is elucidated Georg Christoph Tholen’s article (1997) about the ‘anamneses of the unrepresentable’ with regard to the ‘conflict over the forgotten’ in the context of the Shoah – Holocaust – Auschwitz (ibid. 225).

4. Conclusion and Outlook

The uses and disadvantages of forgetting provide us with plenty to ponder about. As I have shown, the works of Halbwachs provide a first sociological access to collective memory in order to analyze and better understand the processes of remembering and forgetting. To be sure, his work happens to require critical developments and refinements, which I discussed here through the work of Ricoeur as well as Aleida and Jan Assmann. All these authors assume beyond question the notion that forgetting involves many various implicit dimensions and is assigned diverse functions on both the individual and collective levels. The most important insights can be summed up in three points:

(1) *The loss of social frameworks fosters and accelerates forgetting*: here Halbwachs' insight proves helpful according to which the faculty of memory depends essentially on embeddedness in social frameworks. We forget things particularly quickly and durably, if we are unable to anchor them socially in groups or connect them to groups. This has thoroughly practical consequences: research on Alzheimer proceeds on the assumption that a socially active environment can encourage mental activity and alertness (Förstl 2009). To this extent, a measure of protection may well be to keep social frameworks from dissolving, especially in old age. Loneliness and isolation foster the process of forgetting, because without communicative exchanges, memories fade or are lost.

(2) *The indissoluble entanglement of memory and forgetting*: Halbwachs himself endeavoured to work through the entanglement, or better put, the constitutive correlation, of memory and forgetting. To this extent, it would be incorrect to qualify Halbwachs 'only' as a theoretician of memory. Ricoeur, as for him, then developed Halbwachs' sociological reflection on the reciprocal interrelation between memory and forgetting. This he did from a social philosophical perspective, grounding it in arguments from the philosophy of language. Halbwachs intuitively surmised the significance of language, which he claimed was the most elementary framework (Halbwachs 1985: 369). However, it was only after the *linguistic turn* that Ricoeur could actually provide arguments for the necessary linkage of memory to narrative

structure. Memories only become socially alive, if they are narrated and exchanged. That memory is constructive and thereby always selective stems precisely from the fact that it entails a governing narrative logic and the concomitant obligations to establish tension and ensure a structure of meaning. Paradoxically put: selective memory is always already a selective forgetting.

(3) *Memory and Forgetting: Beyond Identity and Consensus*

Collective memory reinforces cohesive and identity-forming processes in a group (Nohl & Ortlepp 2008). In contradistinction to Halbwachs, Jan and Aleida Assmann convincingly suggest a stronger conceptual consideration of alterity and conflict as always at work in the formation of groups. By excluding everything that does not belong to a group, the process of identity formation co-generates alterity and conflict potential. The existence of diverse collective memories within and between groups represents a controversial dealing with the past. The discussion over finding an appropriate way to deal with the Shoah attests to this in a vehement way (Tholen 1997). In any dealing with memory and forgetting, the dimensions of alterity and conflict must be systematically included – but this has to be done differently to the way in which Halbwachs does it. Otherwise the upshot could well be harmonizing interpretations of history as well as the imperious organizing of collective memories and archives (Schenk 2008).

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